

Reimagining Day

Background:

Reimagining Day grew out of the Connecticut Department of Developmental Services' (DDS) efforts to support people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) who have varying levels of need in exploring employment or receiving employment support. Reimagining Day gives people the chance to explore these options without having to give up the familiar programs and services they and their families were concerned about losing. After meeting with other states to learn about their employment services, the Employment and Day Services (EDS) team at DDS reflected on its own system and identified gaps. From that work, they developed Reimagining Day by building on existing Day Support Options (DSOs). Reimagining Day integrates an employment focus into day services for people with IDD, regardless of the complexity of their needs. Services can take place both onsite and in the community through partners.

In July 2024, DDS, using funds from the American Rescue Plan Act (ARPA) Section 9817, invited current DSO providers to submit proposals to restructure their programs to implement Reimagining Day. DDS received 17 proposals, all of which were approved. Providers welcomed the opportunity to embed employment-focused options into their day services, with the goal of expanding and encouraging movement toward community employment pathways.

In March 2025, providers across Connecticut began offering Reimagining Day. As of May 2025, there are 19 program sites and 171 participants. Since the launch, the DDS EDS team has been actively monitoring implementation. The EDS team is encouraged (and often pleasantly surprised), by the high levels of interest and engagement from people exploring employment, including many for the first time.

The main long-term benefit of the Reimagining Day program is its support for the progress participants make on IP goals. Some providers are beginning to see participants in the EEO program transferring to the EES program because they have experienced what community employment offers.

What's Important:

Reimagining Day introduces two employment-focused pathways: Employment Enrichment Service (EES) and Employment Exploration Options (EEO).

- » **EES** is for individuals maintaining, supplementing, or advancing in community employment. It is seen as a way for people to have much-needed support to keep up their workplace skills at community jobs.
- » **EEO** is for people at the employment exploration stage. It is seen as a stepping-stone for individuals who are used to 30 hours of non-work services transitioning into community employment.

These two options are classified as DSOs and billed as group services. Each program is held in its designated space at the facility or through group visits to community employer partners. The Reimagining Day qualified provider instructors encompass a variety of trained staff, including provider staff and employment specialists.

Before Reimagining Day, providers across Connecticut worked from a variety of resources to provide employment services. The addition of EES offered an avenue for employed people to

receive employment support with their peers in a group setting. It also offered a formalized, employment-focused program in a day setting for people with complex needs.

Providers were granted the freedom to design their programs, including selecting their preferred curricula. Some providers developed their own programs, while others used a vetted curriculum such as Project SEARCH. Nevertheless, the objectives for each pathway continue to align. The EDS unit provides oversight and technical assistance to ensure that these programs maintain a strong emphasis on employment.

What Happened:

The Connecticut team is tasked with monitoring the providers' success through site visits and assessing program compliance according to established criteria. These standards include:

- » meeting targeted enrollment goals and project timelines
- » having different designated spaces for EES and EEO classes
- » designating community partners for individuals and staff to visit to learn about the work environment and paid job possibilities or volunteer opportunities, with the focus on future growth and sustainability

During the visit, the Connecticut team compared observations to the initial plan the provider had developed. The team will conduct ongoing visits to assess progress and monitor consistent compliance with the service model. This is done to reinforce that the focus remains on community employment.

Although the classes happen in group settings, they are designed around attaining goals in the participants' Individualized Plans (IP). Individuals participate together in a class on job interviewing or career exploration in EEO, a group discussion about workplace-appropriate conversations in EES, or a small group visit to employers to learn what people do at the jobsite. The Connecticut team is hopeful that Reimagining Day is a step toward individualized employment in the community.

The Connecticut team reports that EEO participants are excited to get to their classes. Some participants have exceeded the state team's expectations about their ability to learn, and they have found the material and interactions so interesting that their behaviors signaling distraction and boredom have decreased.

The main long-term benefit of the Reimagining Day program is its support for the progress participants make on IP goals. Some providers are beginning to see participants in the EEO program transferring to the EES program because they have experienced what community employment offers. DDS anticipates providers who maintain high expectations and standards in accordance with their DDS-approved plan will support more community employment for Reimagining Day participants.

Although the initial launch included incentives for providers to use Reimagining Day, providers have received guidance on how they can add EEO and/or EES at any time through a simplified process.

Questions to Consider:

- » In your state, how often are employment goals included in the Individualized Planning process for people with high levels of need?
- » If your state has a long history of facility-based services, could a gradual but time-limited introduction to community employment be an effective path toward achieving paid work in the community?

Disclaimer:

As you explore today's Spotlight, remember that these practices are shared to spark learning and conversation across states. They represent local innovation in progress—not finalized models or endorsed approaches. Our goal is to surface insights, ask better questions, and learn from another's experiences.

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**State Employment
Leadership Network**



The SELN is a place for states to connect, collaborate, and create cross-community support regarding pressing employment-related issues at state and federal levels for individuals with developmental disabilities.

The SELN was launched in 2006 as a joint program of the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services and the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston.

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